

Motherboards

The winner of our Best Performance Award is undoubtedly the MSI 845PE Max2. This board is built around the Intel 845PE chipset that supports HyperThreading and comes with a six-channel sound capability through its onboard AC'97 5.1-



MSI 845PE Max2: The MSI supports HyperThreading, Bluetooth and RAID

channel sound decoder. The motherboard supports a maximum of 2 GB of DDR RAM with three DIMMs slots. A Gigabit Ethernet controller is also integrated on the board. Another interesting feature is the presence of an onboard Promise RAID controller with RAID 0 as striping and RAID 1 as mirroring. The board is also USB 2.0 ready and has six PCI slots, one 4x AGP slot and one CNR slot. Diagnostic LEDs help trace system problems without opening the chassis. Live Update, a BIOS updating software for Windows, lets you update the BIOS in a snap. PCAlert4, a diagnostic utility, gives information about various system parameters, such as CPU temperature, core voltage and fan speed, and displays a warning when threshold limits are crossed. The board has a very decent design with a fairly simple layout. But the space around the processor feels a little cramped since the power connector is present right next to the processor, along with the RAM modules. Thus, very little space is left, making removing the power connector a problem. All other connectors are logically placed and easy to access. The AGP card has a lock that helps in securing the display card firmly to the slot.



Mercury KOB650GL NDSMx: Onboard sound and video make the Mercury an ideal low-cost solution

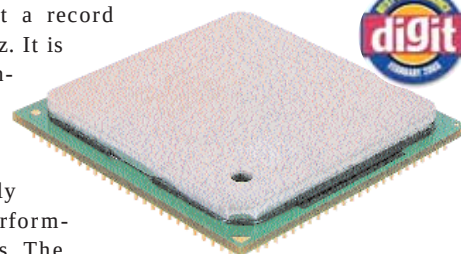
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As far as the best value motherboard goes, our choice was clear. The Mercury KOB650GL NDSMx takes the Best Value Award without any hurdles. This board features support for the socket 478 range of Intel processors. One of the features that you could find handy in this board is that it supports both DDR and SDR memory standards. The board features onboard graphics but does not leave out on the AGP 4X port either. Apart from this

you will also find onboard sound, USB 2.0 and Ethernet support. The only area where we found the board could have done better was the number of PCI slots—it features just two. The board is extremely suited for running office and Internet applications and its low price makes it a great buy. The package includes the manuals, driver CDs and the necessary cables.

Processor

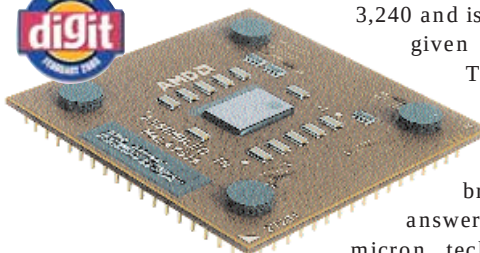
Our Best Performance Award for processors goes to the P4 3.06 GHz. Intel's latest and fastest processor runs at a record speed of 3.06 GHz. It is built on the North-



Intel Pentium 4 3.06 GHz: Now, with HyperThreading, this P4 is the fastest consumer chip in the market

wood core, so we have 512 KB of L2 cache that would definitely please all the performance-hungry users. The processor features Intel's much-hyped HyperThreading technology, which makes the OS think as if it were working with two processors instead of one. The processor left no stone unturned to post some of the best scores ever and stayed ahead of the competition in most of the benchmarks. The processor makes the ultimate buy for those who demand the best performance, price no barrier.

The AMD Athlon XP 1700+ takes the Best Value Award for processors. It is priced at Rs 3,240 and is quite the bargain, given its performance.



AMD XP 1700+: Based on the Thoroughbred core, the 1700+ runs cool and affordable

The 1700+ we received was built on the thoroughbred core, AMD's answer to the 0.13-micron technology. Due to this, the processor consumes less power as compared to the previous core, the Palomino. The Athlon XP1700+ features 256 KB of L2 cache and the Front Side Bus runs at a speed of 133 MHz DDR. As far as performance goes, this one does impress, considering its price. It was able to beat all its competitors with its price-to-performance ratio and scored the highest rating of 78.35 overall STTI.

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